

Jaidon Lapuz

Wendy Ramirez

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Asthma in School-Age Children

Asthma is one of the most common chronic illnesses affecting children in the United States, particularly during their school years. It impacts children's ability to learn, participate in physical activities, and attend school regularly. Understanding asthma—its causes, symptoms, treatment, and prevention—is essential for educators, health professionals, and communities to ensure that students with asthma can thrive academically and socially.

Description

Asthma is a chronic inflammatory disorder of the airways that leads to repeated episodes of wheezing, shortness of breath, chest tightness, and coughing. These episodes are often worse at night or early in the morning. Asthma causes the airways to swell and narrow, making it difficult to breathe. When a person with asthma encounters triggers—such as allergens, cold air, or respiratory infections—the bronchial tubes become inflamed, the muscles tighten, and excess mucus is produced, narrowing the airways even more (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention).

Asthma is not caused by a single infectious agent. Instead, it develops due to a combination of genetic and environmental factors. Children with a family history of asthma or allergies are more likely to develop the condition. Environmental risk factors include exposure to

allergens such as dust mites, pollen, pet dander, mold, air pollutants, and secondhand smoke. Respiratory infections during early childhood and sudden changes in weather can also contribute to its development (National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute).

Asthma is not contagious; it cannot be spread from one person to another. However, viral infections such as the common cold—frequent triggers of asthma attacks—are communicable through airborne droplets and contaminated surfaces. Signs of asthma (which are objective and visible) include wheezing, persistent coughing, rapid breathing, nasal flaring, and chest retractions. In severe attacks, bluish discoloration around the lips or fingernails may appear. Symptoms (which are subjective and harder to measure) include chest tightness, difficulty breathing, fatigue, and anxiety during episodes.

There is no incubation period for asthma because it is not caused by a pathogen. Similarly, asthma itself has no communicable period, though respiratory infections that trigger asthma may be contagious for several days.

Incidence and Prevalence

Asthma is a major public health concern in the United States. According to the CDC, about 4.5 million children currently have asthma, which is roughly 6 percent of all children (“Asthma Data, Statistics, and Surveillance”). Approximately 1 in 12 children has been diagnosed with asthma at some point. Asthma is also a leading cause of school absenteeism, accounting for over 13.8 million missed school days annually (CDC). While the overall prevalence of childhood asthma has stabilized in recent years, significant disparities remain. Black and Puerto Rican children, as well as those from low-income families, experience higher rates of asthma and more severe outcomes (American Lung Association).

Treatment

Although asthma cannot be cured, it can be effectively managed through a combination of medication, trigger avoidance, and action plans. Quick-relief medications, such as short-acting beta₂-agonists like albuterol, are used to quickly relax airway muscles during attacks. Long-term control medications, including inhaled corticosteroids such as fluticasone or budesonide, reduce airway inflammation and prevent symptoms from worsening. Some children may also receive leukotriene modifiers or long-acting bronchodilators for persistent asthma. For those with allergic asthma, antihistamines or allergy shots may be recommended (National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute).

Treatment is typically managed by pediatricians, with referrals to specialists for more severe cases. Schools often keep inhalers or nebulizers on hand to support children during school hours. Severe asthma attacks may require emergency medical care or hospitalization.

Prevention

Prevention focuses on reducing triggers and maintaining control of the condition. This includes regular cleaning to minimize allergens, using air filters, avoiding exposure to smoke, ensuring children take their controller medications consistently, and receiving annual flu vaccinations to prevent respiratory infections. Education plays a major role: children and their families are taught how to recognize early warning signs and use inhalers correctly. Schools also create asthma action plans so that teachers, nurses, and staff know how to respond to emergencies (Environmental Protection Agency).

Community Impact

On the federal level, the CDC's National Asthma Control Program (NACP) funds local and state initiatives that provide education, surveillance, and community interventions. The Environmental Protection Agency runs the *Indoor Air Quality Tools for Schools* program, helping schools reduce environmental triggers. At the state level, many states require schools to have asthma action plans and allow students to self-carry inhalers. Some states also train school personnel in asthma management. Locally, community organizations and nonprofits like the American Lung Association implement the *Asthma-Friendly Schools Initiative*, which trains staff and assesses school environments (American Lung Association).

Implications for Educators

Teachers play an essential role in supporting students with asthma. In the classroom, they can help prevent flare-ups by avoiding strong perfumes, monitoring for dust or mold, and ensuring good air circulation. Teachers should know where a student's inhaler is stored and understand the steps in their asthma action plan. Creating a safe space where students can go during an episode is important. Flexibility in physical activities is often needed—teachers may allow rest breaks or modified exercises during gym or recess. Additionally, educators can provide alternative assignments when students miss class due to asthma. Promoting understanding among classmates can reduce stigma and foster a supportive environment.

Works Cited

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